

Spilotes pullatus

Tiger ratsnake



Length 5–6½ ft (1.5–2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Not evaluated

Location Central America, N. and C. South America



The tiger ratsnake may be yellow with black bands or spots, black with yellow bars, or black with yellow-centered scales. Its triangular, deep body, which is flattened from side to

side, allows the snake to remain rigid while it bridges gaps between branches. Active mainly at night, the tiger ratsnake stalks lizards, frogs, and small mammals, then suddenly strikes out, catching its prey by surprise. When threatened, this snake flattens the front part of its body and forms an S-shaped coil; it may also deliver a strong bite.



Opheodrys aestivus

Rough green snake



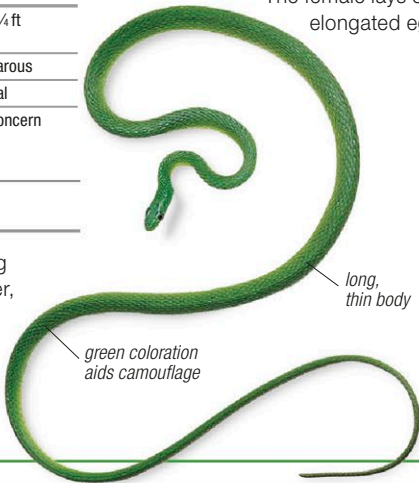
Length 2½–5¼ ft (0.8–1.6 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.E. USA



Often found among low-growing vegetation, especially near water, this snake is bright green with a white or yellowish green underside. The scales are keeled, hence the rough texture of its skin. Although

it typically remains motionless, or moves slowly through vegetation hunting for insects, it is capable of fast movement. The female lays 3–13 elongated eggs.



Pituophis melanoleucus

Pine snake

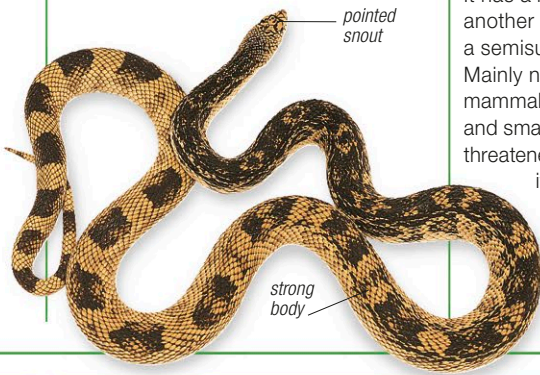


Length 3¼–8¼ ft (1–2.5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Least concern

Location S.E. USA



This thickset, powerful constrictor has strongly keeled scales and a slightly pointed snout that is adapted for burrowing. Its coloration is variable, ranging from uniformly black or white to cream or yellowish, with irregular blotches of dark brown or black down the back and flanks. An active forager, it seeks out small mammals, especially burrowing species. The female lays 3–27 eggs in burrows that she often digs herself, using a loop in the front part of her body to remove sand or soil. There are several species of pine snakes, one of which (the Louisiana pine snake) is endangered.



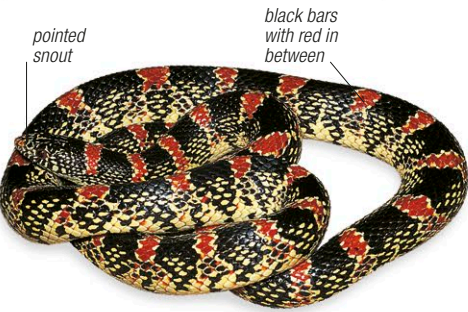
Rhinocheilus lecontei

Long-nosed snake



Length 20–39 in (50–100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Least concern

Location S. USA, N. Mexico



The long-nosed snake lives under rocks and logs, and in rodent holes, and uses its pointed snout for burrowing. It has a markedly underslung jaw—another adaptation that suits it to a semisubterranean way of life. Mainly nocturnal, it feeds on small mammals and birds, as well as lizards and small snakes and their eggs. When threatened, the long-nosed snake hides its head in its coils, vibrates its tail, and discharges a foul-smelling liquid from its anal gland. Females lay one clutch, or sometimes 2, of up to 9 eggs.

Telescopus semiannulatus

African tiger snake



Length 3¼–4 ft (1–1.2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location Southern Africa



A nocturnal hunter, the African tiger snake has large eyes that help it see better in the dark. Its slender, smooth-scaled body is yellowish brown, orange, or pinkish brown, with black blotches that extend across the back as far as the flanks. This slow mover lives mostly on the ground, but also climbs into shrubs, dead trees, and thatched roofs.

Thamnophis proximus

Western ribbon snake

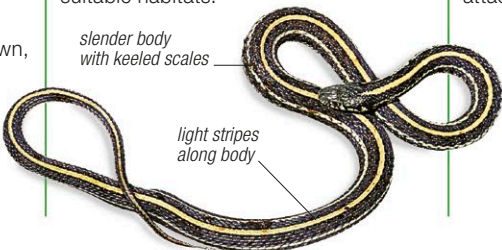


Length 20–39 in (50–100 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Least concern

Location C. USA to Central America



Like its close relative the common garter snake (see right), this North American snake is fast-moving and agile, as well as being a good swimmer. It feeds mainly on frogs, toads, tadpoles, and small fishes, often pursuing its prey underwater. Western ribbon snakes give birth to up to 24 live young a year, and can reach high densities in suitable habitats.



Thamnophis sirtalis

Common garter snake



Length 26–51 in (65–130 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Least concern

Location North America



The common garter snake invariably lives close to water, but it has the distinction of breeding farther north than any other snake in the Americas. On the fringes of the Arctic, it hibernates en masse, creating an extraordinary spectacle when large numbers of snakes emerge in spring. Common garter snakes feed mainly on earthworms, fishes, and amphibians, and are themselves attacked by mammals and birds of prey.

PHYSICAL APPEARANCE

The 11 subspecies of common garter snakes vary greatly in coloration. Shown here is the vividly striped subspecies *T.s. infernalis*, the San Francisco garter snake.



MATING PATTERNS



Mating systems vary according to latitude. In the north of the range, males scramble to compete for females, which they often outnumber greatly, as they emerge from hibernation dens. Toward the south, competition is less frenetic.